of political conflicts and wars in South India . . . cannot be understood in terms of a simple Hindu-Muslim conflict. In the words of the Historical Atlas of South Asia, for example, "both Hindu and Muslim states fought among themselves as much as they did against one another."'[45] There is no evidence, writes Eaton, that Rama Raya's 'contemporaries saw him as a defender of Hindu dharma or the Deccan itself as a region permanently divided between a Muslim north and Hindu south'.[46] Such a framing is largely a projection of later passions and prejudices upon the past.

As we've seen, Vijayanagar's elites embraced many Persianate norms and customs and hired Turkish fighters and commanders. Likewise, the Deccan Sultanates hired Hindu officials and army men. 'In terms of court ritual, fiscal structure and imperial style,' writes historian Sanjay Subrahmanyam, 'Vijayanagara shares far more with the Bahmani sultanate and its successors at Bijapur and Golconda, than with the Pallavas and Cholas. Politically, the rulers of Vijayanagara were as often allied to these sultanates as opposed to them, while amongst their major rivals and enemies were the [Hindu] Gajapati rulers of Orissa.'[47] In the realpolitik of both rajas and sultans, religion was one factor alongside many other pressing worldly concerns. At times, much like today, religion was cynically deployed to unite people for a cause, mobilize emotions or camouflage dubious material objectives. In the 1360s, for instance, the Vijayanagar king annexed Madurai from the Bahmani Sultanate, but he cheekily claimed to have done so in the name of 'a new dharmic kingship and an end to Muslim oppression'.[48]

It's true that Hinduism and its cultural institutions got more patronage in Vijayanagar Empire than under Islamic regimes (and vice versa). In the latter case, any loss of state patronage for Hinduism was felt most acutely by upper-caste Hindus. Most others—lower-caste Hindus, the outcastes and tribal groups—either continued with their folk religiosity beyond the norms of Brahminical Hinduism, or converted to Islam to improve their lot, or evolved syncretic religious forms. Continuity, disruption and renewal were all in play, and outcomes were rarely as black and white as modern nationalists—usually upper-caste Hindus—imagine them to be. The kings of Vijayanagar were not mainly defending Hinduism against Islam; they